

The Victorian Age

(1837-1901)



AUDIO

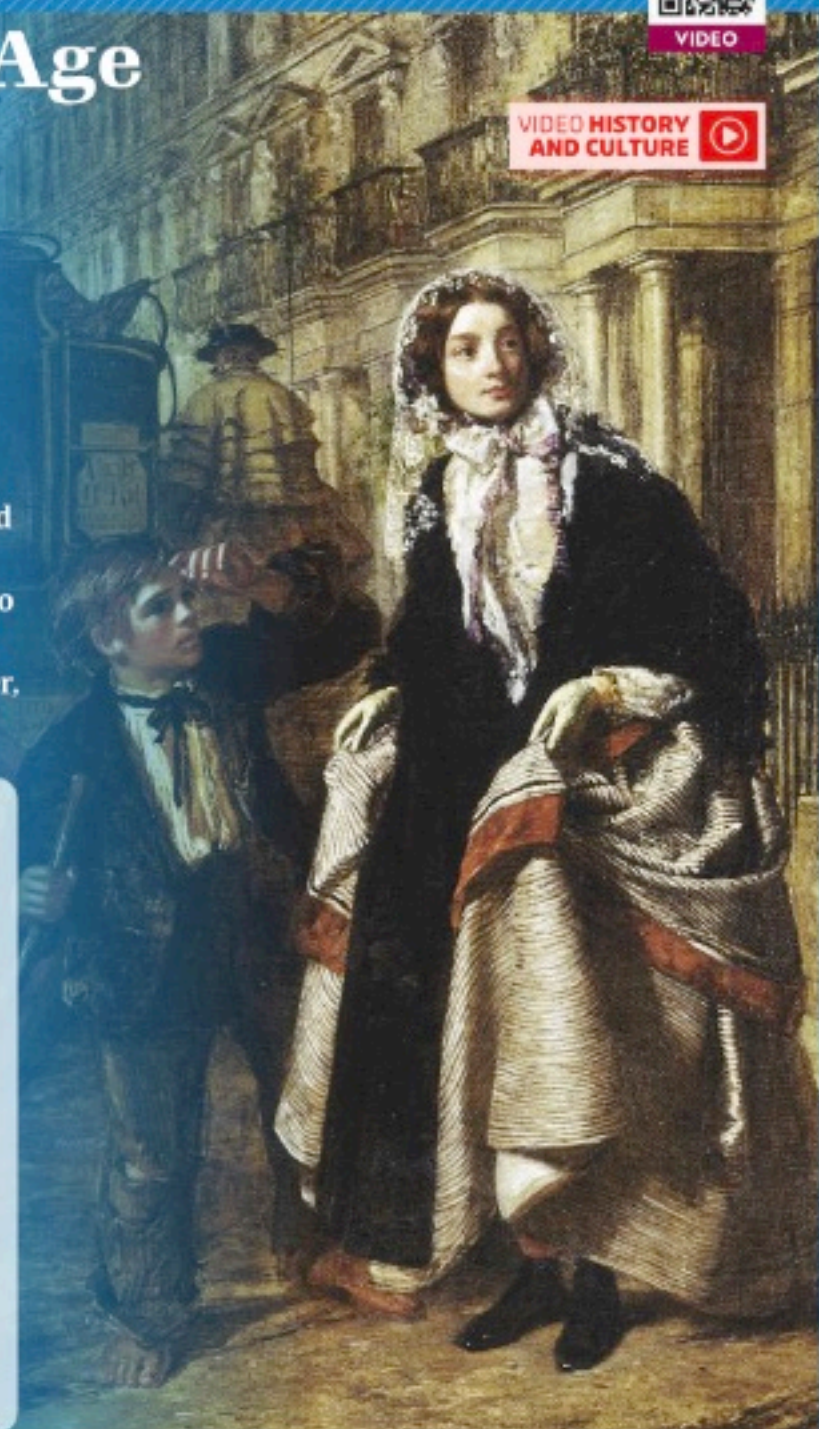


KEYTOPICS Across the ages

The Victorian Age, a period defined by the nearly 64-year reign of Queen Victoria, witnessed progress in science, industry and technology as well as a rapid expansion of the British Empire and the wealth of the nation. At the same time, however, it brought into the foreground issues of (in)equality, stark contrasts and opposites, and isolation often affecting the poorer, undefended sections of society.

GRASP the ESSENCE

The Victorian Age was a period in British history dominated by striking **OPPOSITES**. The age saw an incredible acceleration of the development of **SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY**, which promoted revolutions in transport, communications, and production and significantly contributed to modernising the country. At the same time, such progress enhanced the existing divide between the wealthy and the poor, forcing the latter to live in inhuman conditions and provoking significant social inequalities. The need to promote **EQUALITY** was perceived and shared among intellectuals and artists, who used their work to advocate for social change, economic reforms, and more sustainable working conditions. In an age dominated by the triumph of often uncontrolled progress, it was not infrequent for people to feel a deep sense of **ISOLATION**, which acquired different forms such as rebellion, alienation, and even madness.



VIDEO

VIDEO HISTORY AND CULTURE



OPPOSITES

Focusing on the 1 between contrasting opposites – such as good vs evil; childhood vs adulthood; freedom vs oppression; love vs hate – is a key to understanding the 2 nature of a historical epoch.

LITERARY WORKS

- C. Dickens, *Oliver Twist* → p. 269
- O. Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* → p. 305
- O. Wilde, *The Importance of Being Earnest* → p. 318

SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

The progress of humanity is fuelled by the developments of science and technology, which bring about 3 advancements, but also many 4 and dangers.

- C. Darwin, *On the Origin of Species* → p. 254
- C. Dickens, *Hard Times* → p. 276
- R.L. Stevenson, *The Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* → p. 298

EQUALITY

Equality is reached when everyone is treated 5 discrimination of any sort does not happen, and everyone has the same 6 and opportunities regardless of factors such as gender, race, socioeconomic status.

- E. Brontë, *Wuthering Heights* → p. 286
- T. Hardy, *Tess of the d'Urbervilles* → p. 310

ISOLATION

Spending time with oneself is an 7 condition: it can make individuals feel excluded, generating anxiety and frustration, but it can also help them find resources to know themselves better and be more 8

- E. Brontë, *Wuthering Heights* → p. 281
- C. Brontë, *Jane Eyre* → p. 290, → p. 292
- O. Wilde, *The Picture of Dorian Gray* → p. 305
- N. Hawthorne, *The Scarlet Letter* → p. 326
- E. Dickinson, *I'm Nobody, Who are you?* → p. 334

1 Complete the definition of the **KEYTOPICS** of Chapter 5 with the following words.
ambivalent | positive | juxtaposition | focused | risks | complex | rights | fairly

HISTORY TIMELINE

1800



1837
Victoria becomes Queen

1848
Karl Marx's *The Communist Manifesto*

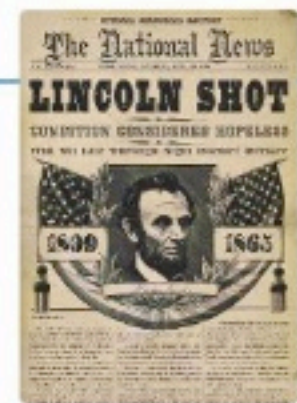
1851
The Great Exhibition



1861
The beginning of the American Civil War

1863
Emancipation Proclamation by President Abraham Lincoln
First underground railway line in London

1865
End of the American Civil War
Assassination of Abraham Lincoln



1876
Queen Victoria crowned 'Empress of India'



1899
The beginning of the Boer War

1901
Death of Queen Victoria





QUEEN VICTORIA'S REIGN: PROGRESS AND POVERTY



LEAD IN

1 Look at the two pictures, both illustrations by Gustave Doré from *London: a Pilgrimage*, a book with texts by William Blanchard, published in 1872. Then answer the following questions.

1. What do the two images have in common?
2. Where are the images set?
3. What strong contrasts do the images offer?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

VOCABULARY Lab

2 Arrange these ten words in five pairs of opposites.

- | | | | | |
|----------|--------------|-----------------|-------------|----------------|
| 1. weak | 3. public | 5. strong | 7. private | 9. independent |
| 2. clean | 4. dependent | 6. rich/wealthy | 8. polluted | 10. poor |



↑ Queen Victoria at the Drury Lane Theatre, November 1837 by Edmund Thomas Parris (ca. 1837), oil on canvas, Royal Collection.

Victoria, the niece of William IV, was just 18 years old when she became queen in 1837. During her reign (1837-1901), the country enjoyed the benefits of the industrial revolution and of its relative territorial and political stability and had come victoriously through the turmoil of the revolutionary and Napoleonic periods. It could boast a growing economy, a growing population and an expanding worldwide empire.

Social and political reform. Despite a growing economy, there was great urban poverty and social injustice. The Reform Bill of 1832 had given the vote to the male middle class, but had done less than nothing for the working class. Discontent among workers saw the rise of the first working-class mass movement – the Chartist Movement (1838). In 1839 the movement presented Parliament with a petition, 'The People's Charter', calling for universal male suffrage and parliamentary reform. The Charter did not obtain any immediate results, but it paved the way for the Reform Bill of 1867, which gave the vote to part of the urban male working class, followed in 1884 by a Reform Bill that extended this right to miners and agricultural workers. Following the first Factory Act of 1833, a series of further Acts progressively limited working hours and regulated child and female labour, while the Education Act of 1870 made elementary education compulsory. The Anti-Corn Law League, founded in Manchester, fought for the abolition of the 1804 Corn Laws which had led to high bread prices and suffering for the urban poor. The repeal of the Corn Laws in 1846 marked the nation's shift from an agricultural to an industrial economy.

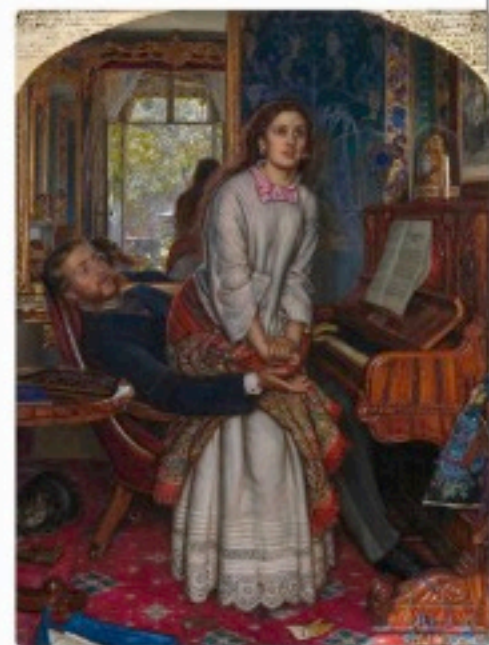
The new political parties. During Victoria's reign the Whig Party evolved into the Liberal Party, while the Tories became the Conservative Party. Their two major leaders were William Gladstone (Liberal) and Benjamin Disraeli (Conservative). Gladstone, four times Prime Minister, tried but failed to give Ireland Home Rule. Disraeli promoted the 1867 Reform Bill, and in 1875 legalised the Trade Unions. The Independent Labour Party developed from the Trade Unions in 1892 and in 1900 became the modern British Labour Party.

Divisions in society. Victorian society was organised hierarchically on lines of gender and class. Gender determined every aspect of an individual's potential and character. Men were physically strong and women weak. Men were independent, while women were dependent. Men enjoyed freedoms, even in their sexual activities, which were denied to respectable women. Men belonged to the public sphere and engaged in occupations and politics. Women were generally limited to the private domestic sphere, where they were expected to run the home and raise children. **Class** was economic and cultural. The working class represented about 70% of the population, had very low family incomes and little access to education and leisure. The middle class grew rapidly over the century and came to represent almost 25% of the population. Middle-class Victorians emerged as the moral leadership of the nation and won some political power. The very small, but very wealthy, upper class got most of its income from property, rent and interest.

Poverty. While Victorian Britain became rich and powerful as a nation, there was a significant gap in income (and thus living conditions and opportunities) that kept the classes apart. Benjamin Disraeli (1804-1881), twice British Prime Minister, saw 'Two nations between whom there is no intercourse and no sympathy [...] as if they were [...] inhabitants of different planets. The rich and the poor'. Although the Factory Acts from the 1830s onwards had improved the working conditions of women and children, unskilled labourers¹ were still brutally exploited, working long hours six days a week in difficult and dangerous conditions. Their homes were often no better than slums with no direct access to sanitation and clean water. They could not afford a varied, healthy diet and had very limited free time. These conditions and the serious overcrowding of the capital caused outbreaks of cholera in London. The great epidemic of 1854 cost the lives of 10,783 Londoners but brought a response. The physician John Snow finally discovered the link between the city's polluted water supply and disease. Finally, after the 'Great Stink'² of 1858, when the smell from the River Thames impeded the work of Parliament, London constructed a new sewage system³ that carried London's wastewater out of the city.

Progress. At the same time the nation enjoyed a revolutionary expansion in communications. The growth, from the 1840s onwards, of railway and steamship networks – combined with the invention of the electric telegraph – supported Britain's economic success. After the success of the Industrial Exhibition of 1844 in Paris, in 1851 the Great Exhibition was held in London featuring the greatest collection of art in industry.

Charles Darwin and the evolution. In 1859 Charles Darwin published his thoughts about evolution and natural selection in *On the Origin of Species* (→ p.254). His book was controversial especially with men of religion, as it challenged the traditional belief in both the role of God and the superiority of human beings.



↑ The Awakening Conscience by William Hunt (1853), oil on canvas, Tate Britain, London.



↑ Eventide: A Scene in the Westminster Union by H. von Herkomer (1878), oil on canvas, Walker Art Gallery, Liverpool.

- 1 unskilled labourers: operai senza qualifiche
- 2 Great Stink: Grande Puzza
- 3 sewage system: sistema fognario

CHECKPOINT

3 Answer the following questions.

1. What characterises the organisation of Victorian society?
2. In what senses did men and women live different lives?
3. What was the cause of cholera outbreaks in London?
4. What advances in communication were achieved in this period?

CHARLES DARWIN

On the Origin of Species (1859)



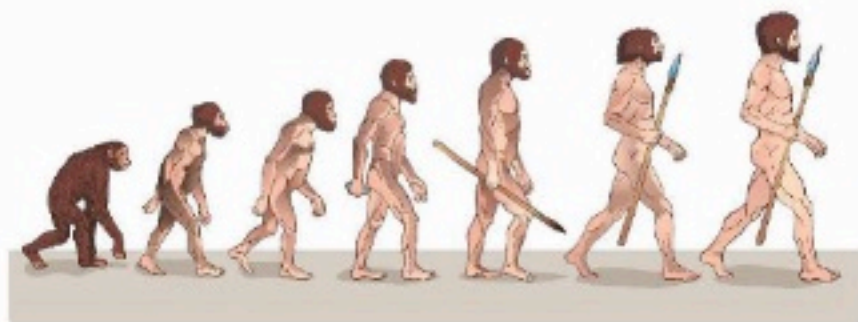
The natural selection

LEAD IN

1 Look at this representation of Darwin's theory of evolution and answer the following questions.

1. What do you know about Darwin's theory?
2. Does the picture represent it?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.



VOCABULARY Lab

2 Complete the table by adding the nouns based on the verbs (1-6).

	VERBS	NOUNS		VERBS	NOUNS
1.	evolve		4.	survive	
2.	vary		5.	reproduce	
3.	select		6.	develop	

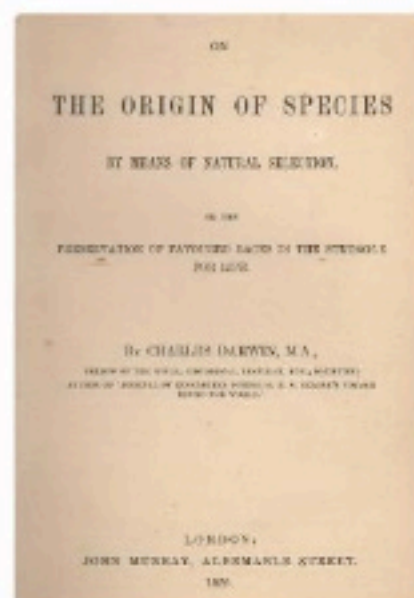


↑ Photograph of Charles Darwin.

115 The following passage, taken from the last chapter of Darwin's book *On the Origin of Species*, contains the explanation of Darwin's famous theory of evolution.

That many and serious objections may be advanced against the theory of descent with modification through natural selection, I do not deny. [...] Nothing at first can appear more difficult to believe than that the more complex organs and instincts should have been perfected, not by means superior to, though analogous with, human reason, but by the accumulation of innumerable slight variations, each good for the individual possessor. Nevertheless, this difficulty, though appearing to our imagination insuperably great, cannot be considered real if we admit the following propositions, namely,—that gradations in the perfection of any organ or instinct which we may consider, either do now exist or could have existed, each good of its kind,—that all organs and instincts are, in ever so slight a degree, variable,—and, lastly, that there is a struggle for existence leading to the preservation of each profitable deviation of structure or instinct. The truth of these propositions cannot, I think, be disputed.

It is, no doubt, extremely difficult even to conjecture by what gradations many structures have been perfected, more especially amongst broken and failing groups of organic beings; but we see so many strange gradations in nature, that we ought to be extremely cautious in saying that any organ or instinct, or any whole being, could not have arrived at its present state by many graduated steps.

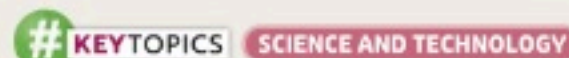


↑ Title page of *On the Origin of Species* (1859 edition).

COMPREHENSION

3 Answer the following questions.

1. Why does Darwin want to summarise his theory?
2. Was Darwin's theory accepted by everyone?
3. What is the role of 'variations' in the evolution of organs or instincts?
4. Darwin's theory rejects God's role in evolution. Why?

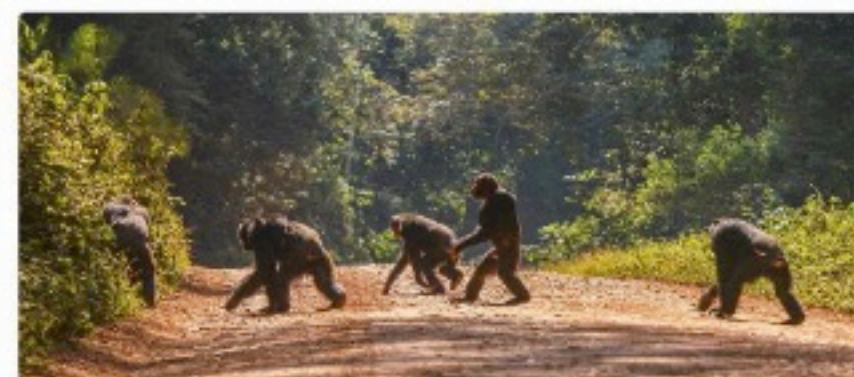


Darwin's theory of evolution. In *On the Origin of Species* (1859) Charles Darwin (1809-1882) explains his famous 'theory of evolution', summarised by **three main ideas**: 1. all complex life forms **have evolved** from simple life forms without the help of God; 2. all living creatures are **subject to tiny variations**, some of which are better suited (fitter) for survival and reproduction in their environment than others; 3. 'evolution' can be conceived as a **tree-like structure** in which branches can be traced back to common ancestors. The **impact of Darwin's theories** on science and philosophy was immense: Darwin's theories propelled the birth of scientific branches such as biology, ecology, palaeontology, and genetics; medicine and agriculture were also affected by Darwin's theories, which promoted the development of more effective breeding practices and the study of the evolution of viruses; in the field of philosophy Darwin's theories revolutionised humans' position in the universe, taking them away from the central position the Renaissance had assigned to them and relocating them in the animal world, subject to evolution like all other species.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

4 Answer the following questions.

1. Why was Darwin's theory so revolutionary for the history of science? Explain this concept in your own words.
2. Darwin firmly believes that 'in nature all modifications are meant to have the most positive effect'. What does this reveal about Darwin's view of nature?
3. Darwin's theory somehow reveals the 'animal side' of human beings. What aspects of human nature do you think emerged with this revelation?



DEBATE

5 You are going to debate the following motion.

The world would be a better place if Darwin had never formulated the theory of evolution.

Divide the class in two teams.

- Team A – the Deniers – will argue in favour of the motion.
- Team B – the Evolutionists – will argue against the motion.

Both sides might consider the following.

- Truth is always a value even if we do not like what it tells us.
- Science cannot be held back by conservative orthodoxy.
- Evolution does not contribute to an ethical society.
- Sometimes ignorance is a necessary factor for human dignity.
- A knowledge of evolution does not bring us benefits.
- The superiority of the human animal is in conflict with the ideas of evolution.

TOWARDS THE 'ESAME DI STATO'

ORACY Lab

6 Use the picture you analysed in the Lead In activity to explain Darwin's theory of evolution and its implications for science, technology, and/or philosophy. Use the Internet to find more connections and expand your knowledge about the various fields of science and technology Darwin's theory has influenced.



Focus on...

DARWIN AND 'SOCIAL DARWINISM'

Darwin's notion of natural selection – the survival of the fittest – was extended into a form of 'social Darwinism' (which Darwin himself did not accept). This idea, proposed by the British scientist and philosopher **Herbert Spencer** (1820-1903), suggested that in society some men became powerful because they were innately fitter, while the 'unfit' were lazy and stupid. Poverty and inequality were thus seen as 'natural', so that laws to help workers and the poor were against the evolution of society.

THE BRITISH EMPIRE: EXPANSION AND COLONIALISM

LEAD IN

1 Look at the picture and answer the following questions.

- Who do you think the woman in the foreground is?
- How is the man in the foreground dressed?
- What do his position and attitude suggest?
- Who do you think the man is?
- What do you think the queen is giving him?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.



↑ A map of the world in 1886, where areas under British control are highlighted in red, by Walter Crane.

Expansion of the Empire. The British Empire came into existence in the time of Queen Elizabeth I and continued for almost four hundred years, with a population of some 500 million people at its peak. Three main interests encouraged the operation of empire building: firstly, **to gain more money** through exploitation of natural and human resources and the creation of new markets; secondly **to gain geopolitical power**. The third factor was seen as a noble mission in the Victorian Age – **to 'civilise' indigenous peoples**. The peoples in the new colonies were presented to the British public as 'lesser breeds'¹, simply because their cultures, religious beliefs and way of living were different. Convinced of their superiority and with a degree of arrogance, 19th-century empire builders felt that it was their moral duty, 'the White Man's Burden' as Kipling puts it, to

travel to new countries and convert people to Christianity and British values, even with force if necessary. Imperial expansion brought plentiful supplies of raw materials to the mother country. It also attracted many people from Britain who wanted to escape from poverty. Between 1800 and 1914 millions of British people emigrated to Canada and Australia to seek their fortunes.

The Empire in India. The expansion and the protection of the Empire was not painless. In 1857 Indian soldiers, *sepoys*, rebelled against their British commanders in the 'Indian mutiny'. The rebellion was quickly and brutally suppressed. Control of the Indian subcontinent passed from the East India Company to British government. In 1858 India officially became a **British colony** and was considered the 'jewel in the crown' of the British Empire. India, with a population of some 300 million people, represented a huge market for trade and commercial exploitation. The new machinery and railway technology that had developed in Britain in the Industrial Revolution was introduced in British India. This brought greater productivity and reduced the time needed to transport large amounts of goods from inland India to the ports, where goods like cotton and tea could be shipped to Britain.

1 lesser breeds: persone di "razze" inferiori

Wars in the Empire. The wars waged¹ during this period reflected the need to protect Britain's imperial interests. The two 'Opium Wars' (1839-1842 and 1856-1860) broke out when the Chinese government attempted to block the East India Company's illegal exportation of opium from India to China. **British victory** led to China ceding Hong Kong and Shanghai to Britain, opened up the Chinese market to commerce and gave free access to Christian missionaries.

The **Crimean War** (1854-1856) saw Britain allied with France fighting to block Russian expansion that threatened Britain's **control of the Dardanelles**. **Britain won** the war but with a **terrible cost in human lives**.

The Irish question. Much closer to home, Ireland was denied 'home rule'² in the form of its own national parliament in Dublin during Victoria's reign. A **devastating famine in Ireland** (1845-47) caused by the failure of the potato crop, the sole source of sustenance for thousands of poor Irish people, led thousands of desperate people to abandon Ireland and emigrate to America and Australia. The failure to give Ireland any form of autonomy would have **serious consequences in the future**.

Dominions. Canada, Australia and New Zealand attracted vast numbers of British immigrants who took possession of the land and oppressed the native populations. These were the first colonies to win 'Dominion Status', which gave them self-government while still owing allegiance³ to the crown – first Canada in 1867, then Australia and New Zealand in 1907.

Africa. The continent was another important target for colonial expansion. In the so-called 'scramble'⁴ for Africa European nations competed for domination of the African continent. Great explorers like David Livingstone (1813-1873) and Henry Morton Stanley (1841-1904) mapped out vast areas of central and southern Africa. In 1875 Britain took control of the **Suez Canal**, connecting the Mediterranean with the Indian Ocean. In 1882 it **conquered Egypt** and then expanded its rule in **Uganda, Rhodesia, Kenya** and the **Niger territories**. The **Boer War** (1899-1902) was fought by Great Britain against the South African Republic (Transvaal) and the Orange Free State, both colonised by Dutch 'Boers' (farmers) in the 17th century. **Britain had already taken control of Cape Town** after the Congress of Vienna. The discovery of rich diamond and gold deposits in the **Transvaal and Orange Free State** led the Boers to fear annexation and to declare war. The three years of bitter war, involving mainly white European soldiers, cost the lives of some 100,000 people. It ended with British victory, giving **Britain control over the two republics**. The Boer War opened up the long road to the transformation of colonies into self-governing states.



↑ Battle in the Malakoff Gorge, 8th September 1855 (Crimean War) by Adolphe Yvon, (ca. 1856-1859), oil on canvas, Palace of Versailles, Versailles.

- waged: condusse
- 'home rule': è l'autonomia legislativa di una provincia o regione rispetto a un governo centrale
- owing allegiance: dovendo fedeltà
- scramble: corsa



Focus on... FLORENCE NIGHTINGALE

Florence Nightingale (1820-1910) is considered **the founder of the nursing profession**. She was called 'The Lady with the Lamp', because she spent her night rounds in **Crimea** giving personal attention to wounded soldiers. In 1860 she founded St Thomas' Hospital and the Nightingale Training School for nurses, offering women new working opportunities.



CHECKPOINT

2 Answer the following questions.

- What factors underpin imperial expansionism during Victoria's reign?
- Why was India referred to as the 'jewel in the crown' of the British Empire?
- What distinguished Australia, New Zealand and Canada from other colonial possessions?
- What criticism(s) may be made of Britain's imperial expansion?

HISTORY AND SOCIETY

INTERNATIONAL, ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL ISSUES



LEAD IN

1 Look at the picture and answer the following questions.

1. What animal can you see in this image?
2. What are the typical characteristics of the animal?
3. What two meanings can 'strike' have?
4. What do you think the symbol and its text might mean?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

VOCABULARY Lab

2 Read the paragraphs and find the English translation of the following words (1-6).

1. crisi
2. panico
3. crollo
4. disoccupazione
5. stagnazione
6. depressione

Panic and depression. Maintaining and defending the military and commercial power of an immense empire spread all over the globe gradually came to represent an ever-higher cost. These difficulties were aggravated by a global crisis, the 'Panic' of 1873 and the 'Long Depression' of the 1870s and 1880s.

The opening of the **Suez Canal in 1869** paradoxically had a negative impact on Britain and was one of the causes of the 'Panic'. The British government was hostile to the canal from the start. Britain controlled the Cape of Good Hope route and the overland route to India. It feared that its commercial and maritime advantage would be threatened by a new route open to all nations. The collapse of the **Vienna Stock Exchange in May 1873** affected finance all over the world. In 1878 the City of Glasgow Bank collapsed through a combination of fraud and unsuccessful investments in Australian and New Zealand mining and agricultural companies and in American railroads. The Bank of England raised interest rates to protect the currency but the economy went into a phase of stagnation. There was heavy unemployment in the basic industries of coal, iron and steel, engineering, and shipbuilding, prices of goods fell dramatically, with grain and cotton losing 30 and 50 per cent of their value respectively. The British economy was the hardest hit in Europe.

Social issues. The working classes were most affected by this depression and began to call for answers. The traditional political parties no longer satisfied the electorate and new, radical solutions were sought. **Socialism** was one of the remedies that was proposed. It was based on the theories of the German philosopher Karl Marx, who called for a new distribution of wealth in England. The **Fabian Society** was founded in London in 1884 by a Scottish philosopher called Thomas Davidson. Its declared aim was to establish a democratic socialist state in Great Britain. One of its early members was **George Bernard Shaw**, who edited the *Fabian Letters on Socialism* published in 1889. The Fabians sought gradual reform and a transition to socialism rather than revolution. The symbol of a tortoise that they chose as their logo, together with the motto 'when I strike, I strike hard', underlines this idea of gradual but determined change. At first they attempted to introduce their ideas in the Liberal and Conservative parties, but later they helped to organise the separate Labour Representation Committee, which became the Labour Party in 1900. The Fabian Society has since been affiliated with the Labour Party.



↑ George Bernard Shaw in the crowd, London (ca. 1910).

FIRST Reading and Use of English Part 2

3 For questions (1-8), read the text below and think of the word which best fits each gap. Use only one word in each gap. There is an example at the beginning (0 = one).

The match¹ girls' strike. In the 1880s Bryant and May's was 0 one of England's largest match-making companies. It employed a majority of young women and girls at its factory in East London. It had a near monopoly of the market, 1 allowed it to pay very low wages and to make a healthy profit. In June 1888, Annie Besant – free-thinker, philanthropist, journalist and orator, and one of the earliest members of the Fabian Society – published an article describing the working conditions of the women at Bryant and May's. She pointed out that the company 2 making enormous profits, while the women and girls were paid a pitiful wage for their dangerous labour. Her article also drew attention to 'phossy jaw', or phosphorous necrosis, a deadly disease 3 by working with the toxic white phosphorous 4 to produce the matches. Bryant and May's reacted to the article by dismissing three women, accused 5 being the 'whistle-blowers' who had spoken to Besant. Within days 1,400 workers went on strike in protest 6 the dismissals. Their strike continued for three weeks, finally forcing Bryant and May's to accept the women's demands for 7 pay and conditions. The company also recognised the Union of Women Matchmakers, formed on 27th July 1888, which soon became the Matchmakers' Union and admitted 8 men and women. The government prosecuted Bryant and May's for having hidden the truth about phosphorous necrosis. In 1900 the company began production with a non-toxic phosphorous compound and called for a national ban on the use and importation of its toxic form.

1 match: fiammifero



↑ Annie Besant, English women's rights activist, with members of the London Matchgirls' Strike Committee in 1888.

CHECKPOINT

4 Answer the following questions.

1. What event in 1869 had a negative impact on British trade?
2. Which manufacturing sectors suffered high unemployment in Britain?
3. What provided the inspiration for British socialism?
4. What change did the Fabian Society bring to British politics?
5. What role did Annie Besant play in the fight for women's rights?

WRITING Lab

5 Write a short paragraph describing the impact of international events on the British economy and indicating the changes it brought about in the political panorama of the nation.

ORACY Lab PRESENTATION

6 Prepare a brief presentation illustrating the condition of women workers in British society at the end of the nineteenth century, making reference to the role of Annie Besant and the match girls.

LITERATURE AND CULTURE

THE VICTORIAN COMPROMISE: EARLY VICTORIAN FICTION

LEAD IN

1 Focus on this definition by Britannica Online: 'A compromise is a way of reaching an agreement in which each person or group gives up something that was wanted to end an argument or dispute.'

Then answer the following questions.

1. Can you give an example of a compromise you have made?
2. What did you sacrifice?
3. What did you gain?
4. Were you satisfied with the result?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

VOCABULARY Lab

2 Read the paragraphs and find the English translation of the following words (1-8).

- | | |
|-------------------|------------------|
| 1. contraddizioni | 5. morale |
| 2. povertà | 6. ipocrisia |
| 3. sfruttamento | 7. comportamenti |
| 4. vizio | 8. riforme |



↑ *Past and Present, No. 1* by August Leopold Egg (1858), oil on canvas, Tate Britain, London.

What attitude characterises the authors of the Victorian Compromise?

Social criticism and the 'Victorian Compromise'. The literary production of the Victorian Age is dominated by one leading genre: **novels**. The **first phase** of Victorian literature includes the works of novelists who write **stories** to represent the Victorian society they belong to in **realistic terms**. Many of the authors of this phase set their novels in **London**, a city that allows them to represent all the contradictions of the Industrial Revolution and the consequences of expanding urban environments. **Early Victorian writers** are conscious of the ethical, economic, and social contradictions that characterise their age (such as poverty, exploitation, and vice) and use literature to make readers aware of them. However, unlike their European counterparts – such as the French realistic writers Balzac and Flaubert, or the Russian Dostoevsky – they **tend to be less critical and more indulgent** towards the society they belong to. This ambivalent attitude is the main reason why the first phase of Victorian literature is often called the '**Victorian Compromise**'.

The Victorian Compromise – a phrase referring to the opposition between the epoch's **public commitment** to solve societal problems using strict moral norms and the **hypocrisy of private behaviours** that were evidently in contrast with these norms – is a common aspect of probably the most famous Victorian writer of all times, **Charles Dickens** (1812-70) (→ p. 264). In his novels Dickens denounces the evils of the Victorian age using a comic tone as a powerful demystifying instrument. Dickens' stories generally have a happy ending, in which suffering and redemption are resolved through surprise appearances rather than through real and effective social reforms.

TOWARDS INVALSI Listening comprehension

3 116 Listen to a historian explaining the origins of the 'Victorian Compromise' and match the beginnings of the sentences (1-7) with the sentence endings (A-J). There are two sentence endings that you do not need to use. There is an example at the beginning (0 = C)

- | | |
|---|---|
| 0. Victorian codes of public morality expressed | A. was nobody's business. |
| 1. The personal reputation of well-to-do Victorians was essential for | B. their public respectability. |
| 2. There were, however, strict laws of defamation which prevented | C. the personal virtues that citizens were supposed to practise. |
| 3. Victorians understood that human beings were weak and | D. the consequences of common lapses. |
| 4. The 'Victorian Compromise' is the result of | E. the clash between high expectations and human shortcomings. |
| 5. In practice, respectable men and women could avoid | F. the belief that all British men were naturally good. |
| 6. What happened behind closed doors | G. public revelation of misbehaviour that could damage reputations. |
| 7. Today we would accuse Victorian high society of hypocrisy, | H. that few could live up to these high ideals consistently. |
| | I. that they could not be expected to teach others how to behave correctly. |
| | J. but the Victorians believed that it was important to protect the reputations of the élite. |

Why did Victorian readers love novels so much?

The popularity of novels. These are the main reasons for their success: the **increase in the number of readers**, due to the higher number of people who could read and write; the **increase in the number of people who could afford to buy books**; the popularity of **circulating libraries**, private institutions which allowed their members to borrow books; the **portability** of the format in which novels were printed made them easy to carry anywhere; finally, **entertaining and realistic plots** that could satisfy many different types of readers.

What is the main 'goal' of basically every Victorian novel?

Victorian novels: style, plots, and aim. All Victorian novels share some **common features**, which represent the 'hallmarks' of a genre that is still extremely popular today. First, Victorian novels tend to entertain and instruct readers, while making them reflect on complex, but not embarrassing issues. For this reason, Victorian novels contain a **moral aim**, which normally coincides with the writer's goal to make readers reflect on the incongruences of the world. Plots tend to revolve around **sharp contrasts** (good vs evil; wealth vs poverty; hypocrisy vs reality; optimism vs pessimism) and are usually **complex, rich in characters, unexpected events, surprises and subplots**. The adventurous nature of the plot of Victorian novels is often the result of a practical fact: to reduce the cost of publication, Victorian novels were often published in **instalments** in newspapers, which forced novelists to write very entertaining chapters to keep the readers' attention alive and make sure they would buy the next chapter. From a stylistic viewpoint, Victorian novels are usually narrated by a **3rd person omniscient narrator**, who acts 'like God' by explicitly judging characters and guiding the readers' understanding.

WRITING Lab SHORT ESSAY

4 Use the information contained in the paragraphs above to write a short essay (max. 250 words) on the reasons why novels were so popular in the Victorian Age.



↑ *The Mudie's of Melbourne, Mr Samuel Mullen's circulating library (1889)*, engraving by M. Prior, from *The Illustrated London News*.